

	Wired	802.11b	802.11g
Switch	1600	-	-
Access Point	-	4000	7600
100 metre wire	2200	-	-
10 RJ45 connectors	80	-	-
5 PCI Ethernet cards	2500	-	-
5 PCI Wi-Fi cards	-	10000	17500
1 PCMCIA Wi-Fi card	4400	2500	4400
Total	10780	20500	29500

insert a PCMCIA card while the laptop is on. Next, right-click the network icon and select an AP, just as for PCI cards.

Securing Your Airborne Data

You cannot limit radio frequencies to the borders of the office wall. It will definitely be visible in the neighbouring areas, making the network open to attack. If, you simply sit and relax after the network is up, you are putting the data of your organisation at risk. Most devices still depend on the WEP security standard, which is not very secure at all. Even a novice hacker, armed with a good

search engine, can find a WEP sniffer to get into your wireless network in no time.

Managing the WEP key is pretty difficult too. Since each mobile client stores a WEP key, it is a nightmare for a system administrator to modify the key for every mobile client to keep enforcing security, or in a situation when one of the clients permanently leaves the network.

The TKIP (Temporary Key Integrity Protocol) in WPA forms part of the final key, which is used to encrypt data.

It also requires a re-keying mechanism between the mobile clients and the AP every 10,000 packets. This process reduces the chances of key detection using sniffers.

The extended IV (Initialisation Vector) reduces the chances of replay attacks. Similarly, MIC (Message Integrity Check) prevents attackers from capturing, modifying and re-sending data packets.

All said and done, WPA is a solution to all known issues of WEP authentication and data security.

Setting up WPA in a home



Comex WL11B+

environment is as simple as setting up WEP. Just think of a key, which could be alphanumeric text. Specify this in the AP as well as the clients. That's it!

Summing It Up

802.11g is killing 802.11b, which is only good for the end user. The speed provided by 802.11g is not similar to that of the speed provided by a 100 Mbps wired network—let alone Gigabit Ethernet. The price you pay for being wire-free is high, but the cost of the setup is coming down.

Devices which retailed for more than Rs 20,000 some time ago are available for less than Rs 7,000 now.



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